4 Prefixes and Suffixes

One of the most common ways in which new words are formed in English is by using *prefixes* or *suffixes*.

> A prefix is a letter or group of letters added to the *beginning* of a word to form a new word, the meaning of which is usually different in some way from that of the original word.

Prefixes

To the word *man,* we add the prefix *super-* (= more/better than) to form a new word *superman*. The new word *superman* means 'a man who is unusually strong or intelligent, or who can do something extremely well'.

> Latin:
> *pre* (= before) + *fix* (= to attach)

Similarly, the prefix *bi-* means *two*. We add this prefix to the word *cycle* (= something which goes round; a wheel) to get a new word *bicycle* (= a vehicle with two wheels).

In Book 3, you have learnt the use of some prefixes to form *opposites* or *antonyms* of certain words:

dis- + *like* = *dislike*
im- + *possible* = *impossible*
in- + *sane* = *insane*
un- + *holy* = *unholy*

Three other prefixes which are often used to form antonyms are *il(l)-*, *ir-* and *non-* :

il- + *legal* = *illegal*
il- + *literate* = *illiterate*
ill- + *fitting* = *ill-fitting*
ill- + *treat* = *ill-treat*
ir- + *regular* = *irregular*
ir- + *responsible* = *irresponsible*
non- + *stop* = *non-stop*
non- + *violent* = *non-violent*

Note: Usually the prefix and the word to which it is added are written together as one word: *dislike, illegal, irresponsible*. However, in some cases, a hyphen is used to separate the prefix from the word to which it is added: *non-cooperation*.

A ***Fill in the blanks with words formed by adding prefixes to the words given in brackets:***

1. Susan ..... her suitcase and took out her clothes. (packed)
2. He was so weak that it was ..... for him to go to work. (possible)
3. Some people think 13 is an ..... number. (lucky)
4. The cooking oil was tested and found to be ..... . (pure)
5. We usually refer to a ..... thing as 'it'. (living)
6. Salim was so nervous that he answered all the questions ..... . (correctly)
7. He lost his way and was ..... to reach the station in time. (able)
8. In 1920, Gandhi*ji* started the ..... movement against the British. (cooperation)
9. The king dismissed all the ministers who were ..... to him. (loyal)
10. It is always ..... to do anything in a hurry. (wise)
11. He ate so many ..... apples that he fell ill. (ripe)
12. Nutan always ..... with whatever anybody else says. (agrees)
13. You must not ..... your parents. (obey)
14. He ..... the door and let the dog out. (locked)
15. He is a ..... man and has cheated many people. (honest)

There are many other prefixes that we use every day, like:
inter-: *international, interclass*
mini-: *minibus; miniseries*
mal- (improper): *malpractice, malnutrition*

mid-: *midway, midnight*
re- (again): *replay, renew*
sub- (below/ less than): *subcommittee, subcontinent, subdivision*
super-: *superfine, superglue, supernatural*
under-: *underground, underhand, underclothes*
ultra- (beyond): *ultraviolet*

Suffixes

A suffix is a letter or group of letters added to the *end* of a word to form a new word. The meaning of the new word is usually different from that of the original word.

We use suffixes for many purposes:

1. To form plurals of nouns by adding *-s*, *-es*, *-en* to the singulars
2. To change the base forms of verbs by adding *-s*, *-es*, *-d*, *-ed*, *-t*, *-ing*, *-en*, etc. to form various tenses
3. To form adverbs by adding *-ly* to adjectives

suf- from Latin
sub (= immediately after) + *fix* (= to attach)

Let us now look at some commonly used suffixes:

(a) *-er: teach + -er = teacher* *work + -er = worker* *read + -er = reader*

(i) In the case of words ending in *e*, only *–r* needs to be added:
sure + -er = surer *pure + -er = purer*

(ii) In the case of words ending in *y*, the *y* has to be dropped and *-ier* added:
dry +-er = drier *carry + -er = carrier*

(b) *-ful: help + -ful = helpful* *care + -ful = careful*

(c) *-less: help + -less = helpless* *care + -less = careless*

(d) *-ness: kind + -ness = kindness* *good + -ness = goodness*

(e) *-ship: friend + -ship = friendship* *scholar + -ship = scholarship*

(f) *-dom: free + -dom = freedom* *king + -dom = kingdom*

(g) *-ment: arrange + -ment = arrangement* *merry + -ment = merriment*

B ***Fill in the blanks with words formed by adding suffixes to the words given in brackets:***

1. Socrates was a famous philosopher and ..... . (think)
2. The fire burnt the whole town down and made many people ..... . (home)
3. John can run ..... than any boy in this school. (fast)

4. Many Indians have died fighting for the ..... of their country. (free)
5. Seeing the ..... faces of the children in the morning made the ..... happy. (cheer, teach)
6. The ..... of the great king was divided into smaller regions, each ruled by a governor. (king)
7. The sky is ..... , and it promises to be a bright and sunny day. (cloud)
8. 'You must be ..... when you cross a street,' warned Varun. (care)
9. The ..... of the universe fills us with wonder. (vast)
10. The mosquito is a ..... of many diseases. (carry)

11. Some snakes are quite ..... . (harm)
12. A magic show had been arranged for the ..... of the children. (amuse)
13. The judge was ..... and let the prisoner go with a severe warning. (mercy)
14. The ..... fell from the horse and hurt himself. (ride)
15. The lack of water causes a lot of ..... to the farmers of this region. (hard)